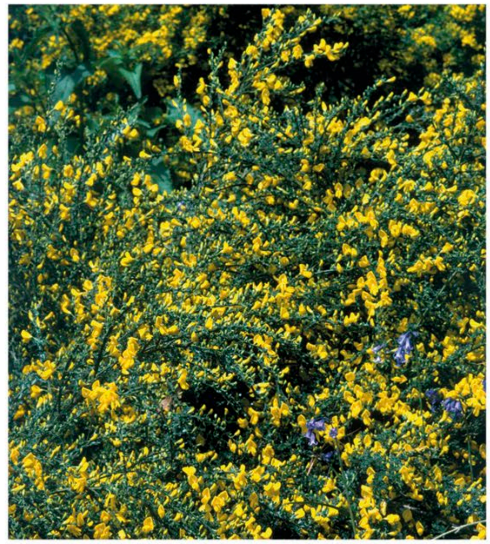
Part Used Rootstock.
Constituents Lady's slipper is poorly researched, but it is known to contain a volatile oil, resins, glucosides, and tannins.
History & Folklore Lady's slipper was held in high regard by Native Americans, who used it as a sedative and antispasmodic. It was commonly taken to ease menstrual and labor pains, and to counter insomnia and nervous conditions. The Cherokee used one variety to treat worms in children. In the Anglo-American Physiomedicalist tradition, lady's slipper had many uses. Swinburne Clymer (in *Nature's Healing Agents,* 1905) considered the plant "of special value in reflex functional disorders, or chorea, hysteria, nervous headache, insomnia, low fevers, nervous unrest, hypochondria, and nervous depression accompanying stomach disorders."
Medicinal Actions & Uses Due to its scarcity and cost, lady's slipper is now rarely used. A sedative and relaxing herb, it treats anxiety, stress-related disorders such as palpitations, headaches, muscular tension, panic attacks, and neurotic conditions generally. Like valerian (*Valeriana officinalis*, p. 148), lady's slipper is an effective tranquilizer. It reduces emotional tension and often calms the mind sufficiently to allow sleep. Indeed, its restorative effect appears to be more positive than that of valerian.
Caution In view of its rarity, lady's slipper should no longer be used medicinally.

Cytisus scoparius syn. *Sarothamnus scoparius* (Fabaceae)

Broom

Description Tall deciduous shrub growing to 6½ ft (2 m). Has narrow ridged stems, small trefoil leaves, and bright yellow flowers in leafy terminal spikes.
Habitat & Cultivation Native to Europe, broom is commonly found on heaths and verges, and in open woodland. It is naturalized in many temperate regions, including in the U.S. The flowering tops are picked from spring to autumn.
Parts Used Flowering tops.
Constituents Broom contains quinolizidine alkaloids (particularly sparteine and lupanine), phenethylamines (including tyramine), isoflavones (such as genistein), flavonoids, a volatile oil, caffeic and p-coumaric acids, tannins, and pigments. Sparteine reduces the heart rate and the isoflavones are estrogenic.
History & Folklore Both the common and species names of this plant indicate its usefulness as a sweeper ("scopa" means "broom" in Latin). Broom's medicinal value is not mentioned in classical writings, but it does appear in medieval herbals. The 12th-century Welsh Physicians of



Broom, *taken under professional guidance, helps to regulate an overly rapid heartbeat.*

Myddfai recommend broom as a means to treat suppressed urine: "seek broom seed, and grind into fine powder, mix with drink and let it be drank. Do this till you are quite well." Broom tops have been pickled and used as a condiment similar to capers (*Capparis spinosa*, p. 182).
Medicinal Actions & Uses Broom is used mainly as a remedy for an irregular, fast heartbeat. The plant acts on the electrical conductivity of the heart, slowing and regulating the transmission of the impulses. Broom is also strongly diuretic, stimulating urine production and thus countering fluid retention. Since broom causes the muscles of the uterus to contract, it has been used to prevent blood loss after childbirth.
Cautions Take broom internally only under professional supervision. Do not take during pregnancy, or if suffering from high blood pressure. The plant is subject to legal restrictions in some countries.

Daphne mezereum (Thymelaeaceae)

Mezereon

Description Hardy deciduous shrub growing to 4 ft (1.2 m). Has oval to lance-shaped leaves, clusters of red or pink flowers, and small red berries.
Habitat & Cultivation Mezereon is found in Europe, North Africa, and western Asia, in damp mountain woodlands. It is cultivated as a garden plant. The root and bark are gathered in autumn.
Parts Used Root, root bark, bark.
Constituents Mezereon contains diterpenes (including daphnetoxin and mezerein), mucilage, and tannins. Though highly toxic, daphnetoxin and mezerein have antileukemic properties and have been used to treat cancer.
History & Folklore Mezereon was formerly well used in northern Europe, both internally as a purgative and externally as an ointment for cancerous sores and skin ulcers. The Swedish naturalist Carolus Linnaeus (1707–1778) recorded that the bark was applied to the bites of poisonous reptiles and rabid dogs. People have reportedly died simply from eating birds that have eaten the highly poisonous berries.
Medicinal Actions & Uses Today, mezereon is considered too poisonous to be ingested. Mezereon is used occasionally as an external counterirritant and is effective on rheumatic joints, increasing blood flow to the affected area.
Cautions Under no circumstances should mezereon be taken internally. It should only be used externally under professional supervision, and never on open wounds.

Mezereon *was once used as a remedy for rheumatic joints.*

Datura stramonium (Solanaceae)

Thornapple

Description Robust annual growing to 3 ft (1 m). Has lobed oval leaves, long white or violet trumpet-shaped flowers, and spiny fruit capsules.
Habitat & Cultivation Thornapple grows in the Americas, Europe, Asia, and North Africa. It is cultivated for medicinal use in Hungary, France, and Germany. The leaves and flowering tops are harvested in summer, and the seeds in early autumn when the capsules burst.
Parts Used Leaves, flowering tops, seeds.